

Prison Ministry trip report.

Entrance of the Theotokos, Nov 21/Dec 4, 2021

(The following is edited from a recording I made as I was driving back from Marshall, TX)

http://www.orthodox.net/prison-ministry/prison-report_2021-12-4+the-goal-is-holiness.doc

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For the first time in the parole house, we celebrated a Great Feast, the "Entrance of the Mother of God." And I was delighted, although it was just Michael and myself, and we missed Jude Thaddaeus terribly. And, of course, we also missed our former resident terribly. We are still adjusting to the loss. All three of us worked very hard and spent a lot of money, time, and our blood to make something a home for someone who needed it, and our hospitality was rejected without any thought about what we had done or what we were trying to do, but only excuses and gaslighting; it leaves a big hole.

We need to buck up and get over it because this is the way life is. The fact is that there is no lock on the door, and everything we do is based on promises made to each other. Those of us running the house, myself, Jude Thaddeus, and Michael, can choose to be honest with each other and keep our promises regardless of what anyone else does.

It was very cathartic to be able to celebrate the services together. It was simple because I sing simply, and Michael is just learning to sing, but we sang the entire vigil, all of Vespers, all of the Litia service, all of Matins, and the First Hour. It took us about two and a half hours. We made a few allowances for our humble situation. I only censed once even though the service called for it multiple times. We said the prayers for Litia (this is a service between Vespers and Matins when we sing some beautiful hymns and then say some very compunctionate petitions addressed to our Lord Jesus Christ and invoking the prayers of the saints, and then bless some bread, wine, oil, and wheat berries) because I didn't bring any of the necessary foods. The following day, we served Divine Liturgy at the bracing hour of 7 o'clock.

In life, the *idea* of things is *easier* than *the things* themselves. The idea of having a prison ministry and helping people get out of prison and rebuild their lives is a wonderful idea! In practice, it is extremely difficult and is fraught with lots of failures, but with our patience cooperating with God's help, some succeed, and we're going to be able to find some that succeed. So, we have to stay with it.

One of the biggest problems of people in prison is that they absorb what the psychologists call "learned helplessness." It takes this form with them. Basically, no matter what they do, everything is terrible in their life. Usually, it was chaotic before prison. After they are in prison, they observe that honesty or kindness or keeping promises often does not help their cause and sometimes even brings punishment and suffering. They live with the expectation that things do not work out unless they, as the clichés go, "stand their ground," and "take care of

business," and "look out for themselves." Many situations elicit immediate white-hot anxiety. The typical reaction to anxiety in prison is to do "whatever is necessary" according to their deluded beliefs of what is necessary, to survive.

If we live our lives expecting things not to work out, they don't work out. We must live as "eternal optimists," even while being at the same time, realistic that in prison ministry, most of the time things don't work out, whether you're visiting people in prison or whether you have a parole or halfway house. Most of the time, people can't deal with their (shall we say, "demons") with that bad thinking that they constantly have in their head.

They can't understand that "Penitentiary Honesty" doesn't work in the world, and it does not even work in the penitentiary. This type of honesty is very flexible ethics; If honesty works, use it; If something else is needed, use that. The trouble with this fungible ethical view is that it becomes hard to know what is true and what isn't, and a person begins to believe his lies and no longer believe that they are lies but are the truth. And, when they're stressed, they go back to things they know, even if they were maladaptive things, even if there are things that got them in prison or just broke up relationships in the past, etc.

All of those things that people go back to are to alleviate their anxiety. Obviously, in extreme cases, there is drug abuse or other dangerous or sinful behaviors. I think it's probably pretty rare for an ex-smoker not to become a current smoker when they come out of prison. They also use destructive coping mechanisms, like outright lying or revising the truth in such a way that they actually believe their revisions, and intense emotions that mask their anxiety or relieve it by distracting them, such as anger, judging, conversations in their head, gaslighting, etc.

The fact is that you can't know a person until you've lived with them a while, until you've seen what they are really like, and not what they have promised. You can only see what a person is like if they go through stressful situations or personal disagreements. You must see people when they are tried and tested by fire, as silver is tried in the fire, to see if what they said is what they're able to do or what they actually wanted. (Psalm 11:6 "The words of the Lord are pure words, silver that is fired, tried in the earth, brought to sevenfold purity.")

A person must want sobriety to be sober. I'm not talking about sobriety from alcohol or drugs. I'm talking about sobriety from those thoughts in our head that command our attention and delude us. When we live in our head, our head is full of delusional thinking. We all have these delusional thoughts, and we must find a way to resist them when they attack us. If you listen to your thoughts, you don't have a chance, because your thoughts will always lead you astray, and the demons are always involved in making suggestions. And your thoughts in your head will never second-guess you and never correct you, and you're never going to do well.

And that is a big problem with people coming out of prison. It's a big problem in the world, everywhere, but in prison, that kind of thinking is entirely normal and acceptable. When there are thoughts in our head that are unchecked, and anytime someone says that they are "standing their ground," or "keeping it real," or "doing what they need to survive," they are actually running away, living in a fantasy, and thinking that they are living in a way that is actually dying. Your thoughts, and my thoughts, and everyone's thoughts, will always lead us to ruin if they are not evaluated by prayer, and the stirrings of the heart, and if we do not seek counsel that we are willing to trust.

We're trying to teach people not to run away and to confront their anxieties and their regrets in life, and to make something out of their life, to find the church, and to live with holiness.

My sermon on the occasion of the "Entry of the Mother of God" was mostly about holiness because, of course, one thinks about holiness when contemplating the Mother of God. The Entrance is a quiet feast that emphasizes the process by which the Mother of God became holy. It's one that very few people understand. Probably more than half of Orthodox Christians do not even know this feast exists, and even if they do know about it, it's not even a blip on their radar. It's a beautiful feast, though, because it shows that holiness has to be cultivated.

The Mother of God didn't just drop down from the sky. God didn't just make her holy like some sort of robot. She had holy parents who prayed for her and dedicated her to the Lord. There were generations upon generations of refinements of human nature in order for Joachim and Anna to pray for a child and dedicate this holy child to the Lord. And in the third year of this child's life, of course, she was then brought to the temple. She then had more seasoning and the experience of holiness by living in the temple. She spent most of her day living in the holy of holies, being ministered to by an angel, and remaining fully in prayer. From the holy of holies, she heard all of the prophecies (many of which were about her) when they were read in temple services, and she ate heavenly food from an angel. All of those things contributed to her becoming holy.

Of course, she had a temperament that would accept this holiness and longed for it, but it wasn't just injected into her. It became organically part of her because she accepted it.

And that's what we have to have in this house. I don't want to be arrogant and consider anything we are doing to be holy like the Mother of God is holy, but basically, everything we do in life should be an attempt to become holy and do things in a holy way.

And in our prison ministry house, we're trying to give a place for people to go to because it's very hard sometimes for a prisoner to find a price to parole, and halfway houses are like "devil's islands." We want to give people a "leg up," help them get a job and get started, encourage them, and help them deal with their anxieties, adjustment problems, etc. The most positive indicator for success for a person on parole is community support.

We want to do all those such things. We are trying to do these practical things: we want to give people an excellent opportunity to make the best of it. At the core of what we are trying to do is live in a holy way and have that holiness help others in the house. And then those people live in a holy manner and bring their holiness out and affect the world. That's at the core of what we want to do in our prison ministry.

If we had a slogan, like companies have slogans, perhaps the best one would be: "Become Holy." That's the purpose of our life; it is to become holy. The purpose of prison ministry is to become holy. The purpose of me traveling to Marshall every other week and Fr David traveling to prisons every week is for everyone we influence (including ourselves) to become holy. We have practical concerns, challenges, successes, and failures, but all that actually matters is that we become holy.

When Michael and I celebrated the holy service commemorating the "Entry of the Mother of God," we got our bearings again; the pop-culture way to say this would be that we had an "attitude adjustment." We got knocked around by our last resident leaving so abruptly, and so much about our last conversation was unpleasant in the extreme. He not only left the house, but he also left all of the Orthodox materials that he owned - icons and Bibles and books and prayer books and the Psalter. It was all left it all behind, whereas it was apparently very important to him for his salvation three weeks before. It was healing and empowering for us to remember what we really are doing here and that our ministry to him does not need to stop because he has stopped.

And, of course, we're not trying to keep anybody from leaving, and everyone in the universe can run away, whether it's from a promise, or responsibility, or something that makes them anxious, or just something that they don't want to do. That's the big temptation that comes with freedom. Freedom can be abused, especially when there has been trauma. Everybody has had trauma. The first inclination when something triggers our trauma is to run. We must fight that inclination.

St. Joseph the All Comely Prison Ministry is not running away. That never does anything for you. When you run away, all you do is bring yourself to another place, but you haven't changed anything because all the wrong stuff is still wrong in your head. And if somehow things can be in your heart, they can influence your head. Then it doesn't matter where you are. You're not going to prosper.

We are not running. I am able to promise that, but I'm not able to promise that I will not think about it once in a while. But if I think about it, it's just demonic thoughts trying to trick me. What are we going to do? We're going to celebrate the services. We're going to be a community waiting for another person to come, and maybe another one after that, and another one after that. For any of that to happen, we must be here. I'll go out here every two weeks; we'll celebrate the services. We will do yard work, raise chickens, and try to learn to weld. We'll do whatever we do, but in the midst of all that, the main job we're going to do is to try to be holy.

Priest Seraphim Holland